Until We Dance, for Joseph

By Jessica Care Moore

INTRODUCTION

Behind every AIDS death is a story. Behind each statistic is a person who is loved, who was someone's brother, mother, father, sister, aunt, uncle, friend, grandparent or lover. The ones who died early on created the most heart-wrenching times -- they were subjected to the worst kinds of fear and isolation, even by those who were supposed to be family. In Until We Dance, for Joseph, Jessica Care Moore explain her 14-year-old understanding of AIDS through the loss of her most beloved family member . . . and she offers her hope for the future of those who are living with HIV and AIDS.

Until We Dance, for Joseph by Jessica Care Moore

I was taught about AIDS
Inside the whispers and beneath the foundation of my
white aluminum Detroit house.
The wind smelled of wild flowers and car exhaust
As I sat on my porch waiting for you to arrive.
Full of smiles joy and candy
You pull up in your car and spin me around with promises
at 14,

4NG Fanatics

that one day we would be as famous as fred astaire and
josephine baker.
I am still dizzy with anticipation.
Spinning like all little girls do when in love.
Waiting for you to show up for our encore performance.
That afternoon my innocence stretched
and pulled into the shape of a
woman's heart.
I was never allowed to see you again.
You didn't want me to.
You didn't know I had old wise eyes
no hospital bed, no four letter word,
no sickness could ever define or contain you.
The phone calls shook our house daily.
The sound of the ring made the butterflies shuffling
inside my stomach begin to return their cocoons.
I was losing you and couldn't tell anybody.
Suddenly, Joseph was an angel. An urban legend. A myth.
A man inside my dreams I'd made up inside my head.
Not the tall brown curly haired man with arms as wide as
oceans.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

I begged my family to let me see you.
Why has Joseph become a secret?
Why can't I visit him just because he is sick?
The day Joseph died.
I lost my breath.
I ran outside to my porch to ask God where the air had gone.
I danced alone for hours pretending he was holding me in the air flying me through the living room with ease.
Then the truth.

****

Finally, I was told of Joseph's condition.
There were rumors of trips to LA and wild parties,
Because, of course, in the 80's no one in the Midwest could contract HIV.
There were no walks, or candlelight vigils or multi-colored quilts to warm me When Joseph died.
There wasn't even an open funeral.
Our family was ashamed of their son

4NG Fanatics

didn't want anyone to come. Including me.
They forgot that Joseph's life
made the world better.
His full, beautiful child-like smile lit up rooms & hearts &
Sunrays battled for his light.
After that week I never wanted to be an adult.
I wondered how many died in silence and how many still do.
I write so their lives are not in vain.
This poem is for New York, Detroit, Chicago, Atlanta,
San Francisco, For survivors around the US.
For Zimbabwe, Botswana, and South Africa.
For the more than 28 million people living with AIDS in Africa.
For the 10,000 that died this morning.
For the survivors, the truth-tellers, educators, organizers, and activists.
Who aren't ashamed
of a hug or sharing a meal
or providing medical care to someone with AIDS.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

For the children born with AIDS who must fight for every breath.

Today we walk with Joseph's wind in our heels with the names of millions in our stride.

I hope we walk loud so no one else dies in silence

Walk hard enough to shake the earth like Shango

Walk outside the boundaries of neighborhood,

of country, of gender, of sexual orientation, of race, of generation, of reflection,

Walk past the idea of not my son, not my daughter.

Walk an inch closer to being better humans.

Walk so no one else learns about AIDS

The way I did.

Without protection. Inside a whisper.

Because every grave needs a flower.

Every survivor has a story worth celebrating.

And this one is for you.

Encore Joseph, Encore.

4NG Fanatics

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jessica Care Moore
Book: The Alphabet Verses the Ghetto
ISBN: 978-0965830874
Publisher: Moore Black Press
Date (Month/Year): June 2003

AWARD HISTORY

WI State Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY